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A Necessary Presence

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CLARE BRYDEN

A Necessary Presence

Lifebelt Poetry

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ISBN 13: 978-1-0654911-0-1

A CIP record for the book is available from the British Library.

First published in 2026 by Lifebelt Press,
a trading name of Exeter Sustainable Enterprises Ltd, Exeter, UK.

lifebeltpress.co.uk

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Cover design and photographs by Clare Bryden.

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to the Sisters at Tymawr Convent
with immense gratitude

All we had to do was be there,
Learn to be still, and let ourselves
be prayed through.

— Martin Olsson "Compline at St James"

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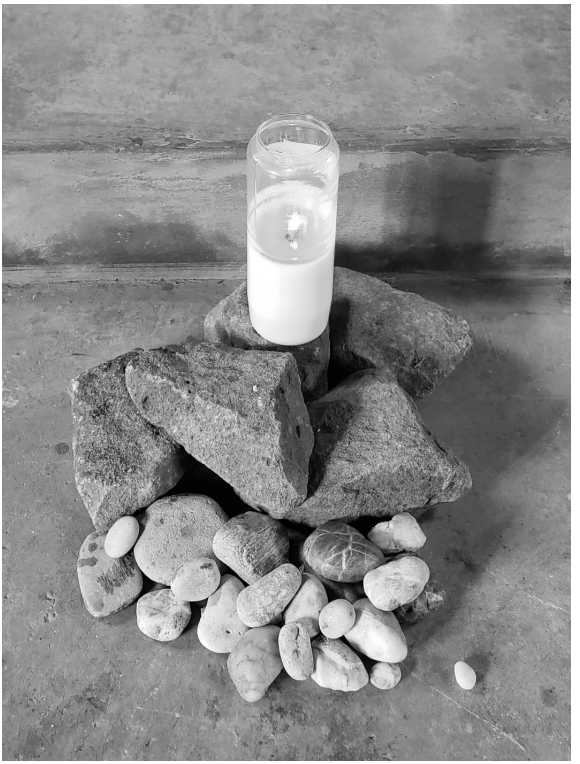
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I

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Malling Abbey, May 2011

I remember solitude.
The Sisters had their work.
The others in our group

had gone to visit Rochester Cathedral.
I'd opted out, preferring to be on my knees
pulling weeds in the hard, dry kitchen garden.

Later I found a place to pray,
a stool on one side of the cloister,
part glassed in, part open to the square —

cobbles, grass, stone flags, central pool,
a gently rippling spring with waterlily leaves
ready as open hands to receive the drifting spray.

I stayed as long as presence in the silence —
pool, spring, lilies — my soul filling and overflowing
in a calling to this way —

not community but contemplation —
templing with — attending to an interior garden,
my own *hortus conclusus*.

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All are welcome

for everyone who knocks, the door will be opened
— Matthew 7.8

I do not need my own key
I do not need to know

a secret code that opens sesame
there is no code, no key

this door will not be pried
however hard I try to frame my way

the host so sweetly
hovers close inside

waits ready at my softest tap to fling it wide
and crack a wider smile

welcome me wholeheartedly
to lamplit halls and lively company

where worldly cares and sorrows fall away
and I abide a while

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Kilpeck Church

for Mrs Browning

When I described Kilpeck Church to you —
my parents having dragged twelve-year-old me on a visit —
I doubt I had much to say about decoding ecclesiastical architecture.

I might have mentioned the carved Norman arch above the south door,
but skipped its likely Celtic origins, the corbel of a pig with a man in its mouth,
the Pugin glass, the sheela na gig and dedications to St Mary and St David.

I suppose that most of what I had to say concerned the what I'd felt inside,
because you gave me something that approached a side eye, your slant
perceiving my encounter with the Holy. I'm reading from a later place of faith —

though now I wonder whether twelve-year-old me stood one foot in that faith
in Kilpeck nave. A necessary presence, traced in glass and stone, in me
these forty years. Back or forth in time — which way do echoes carry?

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Tymawr Chapel speaks

I

Place your hand upon these walls,
hewn haphazard
into a house of prayer.

Trace the Stations of the Cross —
each beam and upright
scratched into fourteen rough, grey stones.

Put your finger in the marks of the masons,
working burnt-rose blocks
fit for an everlasting altar.

II

On the Eucharistic altar are two lit candles,
and three and three tealights
set in a stream of leaves on the sanctuary step.

But the one thing that is needful

is the faintest light kept burning by the sacrament,
the blessing day and night
holding all the darkness in the world at bay.

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III

At five o'clock
the Chapel bell is rung
to call the community to Evening Prayer.

Thirty-three times,
the years of our Lord's days.

Above the altar
the crucified One listens closely

as the final stroke sounds
and fades away,
is silent and lingers.

IV

Yes, my Lord and my God. Come,
scratch your sign on the walls
of my rocky heart.

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Blythburgh

for Eleanor

There is the place where I would stand,
outstretched hand resting on a column
of pure, saturated prayer. For once
not worrying about following another's
rhythm, for you were waiting where the light
streaming through the clerestory windows
was the natural element of angels poised
to swan-dive. There outstretched,
for a moment I could breathe underwater.

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On his Cross

CROSSPIECE — *CHRONOS*

How long has he been hanging there,
eyes askance, as though he cannot bear
to look on us?

A hundred years? A thousand? Two?
He'll have much more to bear
before we're through with him.

UPRIGHT — *KAIROS*

What do crucifixes show?
The dying or the death?

Did his eyes close
when the lids gave in to gravity
on breathing out his final breath?

Has he shuttered them
against the pain?

Or are they piercing down and right
where the penitent thief and I forever
beg him to *Remember us!*

to say *Today*
you will be with me in Paradise?

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Many-storied

Stepping forward to receive the host,
I lift my hands and trip
to see these aide-memoires
scribbled in black biro — blots
not quite scrubbed away.

The left hand, lying awkwardly in right,
prods at my conscience — that call
I meant to make — and traps
my attention — this shopping list.
Too late to change, I commit.

The minister takes a wafer
wrought in crosses, raises it
and speaks — *the body of Christ* —
the Word, then lays it gently
in my waiting hands, rewritten.

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II

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Rewilding

Last moon I dreamt a pine marten
approached my patio door,
stretched up, paws on glass,
and peered in on me. Imagine

opening the door a crack
and she flows across my threshold,
streams and supples and spirals me
up and round and round and down and

up and round and round and down and
finally comes to rest in my arms,
a part of me — she makes no sound
but I understand that I am owned.

Now at prayer, I watch my owner
skitter giddily in circles, causing chaos
scattering the candles, causing chaos
for the joy of it, all of a sudden pause —

one foot in the air —
and rush my knees to nuzzle at my nose,
jump to my head, muss my hair and down
to snuggle briefly in my collarbone.

The winter has been long, but now
the land is welcoming the pine marten.
She and her kits, absent for a century,
are playing in the broadleaf woods of Devon.

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Language Lessons in the Garden of Eden

> *whatever the man called each living creature, that was its name*
> *— Genesis 2.19*

God has been educating Adam
in all the languages of Eden

naming for him
the heavens and the earth
light and dark
water and sky
herb and tree
sun, moon and stars

Now in the cool of the evening
Adam takes his turn

God points and Adam thinks
Hebrew *aryeh*, Aramaic *aryā*
Greek *léōn*, Latin *leo*, Arabic *asad*
Welsh *llew*, English *lion*

So Adam names the creatures one by one
nāḥāsh ḥivyā óphis serpēns
ḥayyah sarff serpent
keves immerā amnós agnus
ḥamal oen lamb

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Corff Crist

we are a larger group today
a wider arc around the altar
        the faintest scent of baking bread

voices mingle softly in three-part harmony
the Body of Christ — Corff Crist
        the Word was made flesh *yn y Gymraeg, hefyd*

a blessing please
the Blood of Christ — Gwaed Crist
        the taste of wine lingers on my lips

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The Spinner

for the community at Tymawr

One hundred years the Spinner has been weaving
a fragile web in this consecrated place.
In love, she has been gently giving

of her body to form the spokes of lace
she tethers firmly to the old oak tree
and threads that hold and bind the space

between. In time each spoke will fray —
the Spinner weaves in old and new, then waits —
content forever to perfect the unity

of now. Again, the storm cloud shakes
its strength. Again, the Spinner patiently renews —
this my body this my body — the breaks.

The web endures the long night through —
the Spinner lights its load of morning dew.

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The Plunge

for Katharine

However well-prepared, the plunge
into a Tymawr May-time overwhelms.
So much spring is calling for attention —

how the wildflower fields full
of clover and oxeye, sorrel and speedwell
and tiny sky-blue butterflies

are already well above my knees
onto which I wish to fall —
give praise — and how

each morning and evening the moles
shovel up the dark red soil in fresh
new earthworks along the paths — and how

the younger trees, bearing the weight
of all their green, are bowing down to greet
upwelling undergrowth — and how

loud it all is! The dawn chorus
joys the whole day through,
two pale purple rhododendrons thrum

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with white-bottomed bumble bees,
and the drumming rain — even the rain —
burnishes the coming sun. And I want to cry

Never get used to this! Never forget
to stop and smell the roses, these and
those roses, those roses over by the house

and those and those and those roses.
Stop and smell every single rose.
Spend every waking hour at it!

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When a butterfly prophesies

Where had you been sleeping,
that the rising November heat
awakened you before the end
of the Eucharistic Prayer?

We receive the bread and wine standing
in a half-moon. You *pilipala* in the window,
cut crazy capers on the carpet, abruptly
fold. On a knife-edge — unfold —

fold — wearily blink your peacock eyes.
Is this a sanctuary or an asylum?
Are you trying to show us light
when you so desperately batter at the glass?

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White Brook

A gap in the branches —
I glance aside — arrested step —
the water in the White Brook
has stopped short

to quiver in the sun,
giddy with joy,
elbowing
mossy rocks.

If I gaze long enough
on the bright skittering mirror,
I slip right through
straight to the quick.

How could I not bow?

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III

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Knit together

for Morwenna

God settles in for the evening,
radio on and latest project to hand:
four double-pointed size 13 needles and a basket of 5-ply yarn.

Your hands made me and fashioned me —
you clothed me with skin and flesh
and knit me together with bones and sinews.

There's a myth
that the home of a drowned fisherman
could be told by his gansey.

When I wash up
on the shore of the river of life,
I am counting on God to recognise my pattern.

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St Columba consults the Shipping Forecast

St Columba keeps his ear to the long wave.
Shannon. Rockall. Malin. As the dove flies

he is praying for a kindly breath
set southerly and fair. And may it sweep

all chaos from the waters before
his curragh of sticks and skin.

Hebrides. Bailey. Fair Isle.
When marauding gales swoop from the north

and vision clouds,
let the body be a fastness.

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Easter Sunday, 2026

Some bloke is lying on the path
along the field ploughed for wildflowers.

He has pulled his hoodie down over his eyes
to shield them from the Easter afternoon.

The last heat in the turf ebbs
into unforgiving ground,

but he can still make out the sun,
even through his eyelids, hood and hand,

and listen to his daughter playing.
She fits snugly in the furrow next to him

taking a worm's eye view —
I hear the earth tastes good.

In a little while he will rise,
reach for his daughter's hand,

brush off the soil
and swing her onto his shoulders.

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Just is

In a split second of clarity
before the Blessed Sacrament

in the tiny transfigurations
of an apple, hand, or leaf

in a good friend's sudden burst of laughter
(it was a brilliant wordplay)

in a gap
in the clouds

in the twitch of a smile
crinkling crow's feet eyes

in an electric blue
flicker flash of wings

how is it that we know
we have just seen God?

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On visiting friends in Loughborough

for Malcolm

Once in a while I would find an hour
to drive to Mount St Bernard Abbey,
buy another piece of rippled
blue-glazed stoneware turned by Brother Potter
and spend some time in prayer.

The best of days, there would be sun
inclined to take the form
of risen and ascended dust,
when I would stay to wait and gaze,
and watch the other faithful,

who enter, quietly bang the chapel door,
dip holy water, cross themselves
and bob a genuflect. Some stopped a second.
Others knelt, with hands folded, an age
as the dust, drifting, came to rest on us in blessing.

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Some of our conversations

after Carrie Newcomer

Some of our conversations have become
songs: the air that is essential silence
humming comfortably beyond all sense,

in sparer moments out of blue, a psalm
for every consequence — delight, appeal,
lament, contentment with a job well done,
a catch at martins tending urgent young,

angelic frequencies re-tuning all
my worrying away at memories
of awkward words — those sighs and groanings spun
to lyrics in unfathomable tongues,

or a miracle of calming harmonies
that, soothing, hush to pulsing lullaby —
our songs that hold the light at close of day.

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Heartwood

HOSPITALITY

Come back with me to Tymawr, where I have found
a spreading magnolia in the house of God —
the ideal secluded tree to hang a hammock,
with two stout branches at the perfect height
and a mossy cushion to rest my head.
Above, a lavish canopy of leaves might
shelter me from sun and God willing
showers, should I ever take the risk.

TWO *LEYLANDII*

This morning I had the strangest sense
the two *Leylandii* beyond Our Lady's Orchard
were about to wake, unfold their arms and shake
their shaggy heads, unbend their knobbled knees,
gird up their skirts, peck a parting kiss
and stump off to their day jobs —
or, contrariwise, were simply glad to squat
merged in each others' congenial greenery.

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STATIONS OF THE CROSS

Fifteen tapped from all the trees tell
the winding tale of inhumanity. Grief and fear
the world's daily companions on this long route
around the convent grounds. Just so.
The line separating good and evil passes

right through every human heart.
The *Leylandii* stand too for Station 14
— the Cross of Inhospitality —
minding all without a place to turn.
The end is close to where it all began.

THE STUMP

Even this mouldering stump may serve
to lift up a crucifix — a small stone frieze.
Jesus is marked out
through the camouflage of moss and weather
by his hands, huge and welcoming.

AND THE DAMSONS

keep on cropping. Pail upon pail.
How on earth could one small tree
bear such a heavy load of dark
sharp-sweet tears?

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The next thing

Yesterday was misty.
I went running in the trees.
Today it is misty again —
beech leaves
showered everywhere, as though there were no
tomorrows.
Now I can only do the next thing —
be kind, pay attention, pray, write a little, share
those poems that tell of reweaving the world.

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ENDNOTES

Malling Abbey, May 2011
Hortus conclusus — Latin, an enclosed garden.

On his Cross
Chronos — Greek, the measured quantitative time of clocks and calendars.
Kairos — Greek, the qualitative moments when time stands still and the world stops.

Rewilding
The pine marten was reintroduced to Dartmoor in September 2024, and the first kits were born in June 2025.

Corff Crist
Corff Crist — the Body of Christ
Gwaed Crist — the Blood of Christ
yn y Gymraeg, hefyd — in Welsh, too

When a butterfly prophesies
The Welsh noun *pilipala*, butterfly, is wonderfully evocative of its flight.

Knit together
Your hands made me — Job 10.8a,11
Ganseys are hard-wearing, hand-knitted, woollen jumpers traditionally worn by fishermen around the British Isles. They are knit from a tough, fine wool of one colour, traditionally navy blue or cream. The fine gauge of the stitches makes dazzlingly intricate designs possible, with an immense range of patterns recorded around the coast.

Some of our conversations
Some of our conversations have become songs — from "Carrie Newcomer: A Conversation with Music", *On Being with Krista Tippett*, 31 December 2015.

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Heartwood
a spreading magnolia in the house of God — compare Psalm 52.8a, Common Worship
"The line separating good and evil passes not through states, nor between classes, nor between political parties either — but right through every human heart." — Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn, *The Gulag Archipelago.*

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Thank you, *diolch yn fawr iawn* to my editor Matt Bryden (no relation!) and to all who read and commented on early and late drafts of these poems. Your support is immeasurably precious.

Versions of a number of poems have previously been published:
"All are welcome" as "Everyone welcome" in *Conversations*.
"Tymawr Chapel speaks" as "At Tymawr Convent", "Kilpeck Church" and "Blythburgh" in *Theology*.
"On his Cross" and "Knit together" in *The Merton Journal*.
"Many-storied" as "Writing on my hand" in *The Christian Century*.
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"Some of our conversations" in *The Silken Twine*, Black Ven Poets.
"Heartwood" in *Advent Newsletter / Cylchlythyr Adfent*, Tymawr Convent.